

I The Master of the Demons

Where are you? Where is this?

You were so engrossed with the parchments in your hands that you did not pay attention to where you were going. You must have taken a wrong turn, for you find yourself in a courtyard you have never seen before. Are you even allowed to be here? But this does not seem to be part of the royal wing. And it's perfect actually: nobody around. No prying eyes while you read your newest discovery: the tale of the Goths by some Roman historian.

It is kind of silly that you did not find it earlier. Here's what happened: a few weeks ago, you were looking for a place to keep another book you just got, a copy of the Gothic history by one Prokopios. This one had been a gift of Lord Yazdak—regrettably not delivered, as you had hoped, by handsome young Shāpur, but by one of Lord Yazdak's scribes. With Mariam's notorious untidiness, leaving those notes just anywhere would just be signing their doom. So, you needed a place to keep them safe. You remembered the old bag you had taken with you from the orphanage with all your stuff in. It took you a while to find it, shoved away in some forgotten corner—a metaphor presumably for a similar shoving away in the corner of your mind of your previous life. But when you opened it, a strong odor of tar and decay almost made you throw it down again, until you realized that the smell came from the torn dress. You had forgotten about that episode, when Mariam and you were both locked up in the belly of a boat, and you had torn your dress, and the captain's boy—*putto*, Mariam had called him—wanted you to take it off! Oh, dear, that memory alone makes you shudder. How close you had come to giving up your chastity. Anyway, after you reached Antioxeia, you must have put the dress in the bottom of your bag. And then you kind of forgot about it.

So, more out of nostalgia than common sense, you took the dress out of the bag, and that's when you saw it! The parchments! It took a few minutes before you realized what they were: the notes Lord Ioannis had promised you. He had told you how his cousin Evagrius had found this manuscript and he had made a copy of it. And in it, it described how *Rex Thiudareiks* conquered Italia. You had expressed interest in it, that it would be good to learn a little more about your Gothic past, to educate Mariam about her ancestors. So, Lord Ioannis had said that you could have his copy, once he had finished reading it. But then stupid Mariam

would have to ruin everything by saying this thing about Lord Ioannis having a crush on you—the gossip of those other orphan girls—and after that, Lord Ioannis kept his distance, and you forgot about the copy. And after that fateful night in his friend’s house in Edessa, well, from then on, he completely avoided you—so perhaps, you really were the stupid girl who ruined everything. Anyway, the noble man he was, Lord Ioannis must have found an occasion to slip them unnoticed in your bag, hoping you would only find out later. But he probably didn’t think it would you stupid girl take 5 years! Anyway, you finally found them.

And as luck would have it, you are free of duty for a couple of weeks, so you can spend as much time as you want reading about your *Regia*’s grandfather, the great *Rex Thiudareiks*. His great great granddaughter Mariam, your mistress, she went with Shirin and the others to Lady Kāren in Gondeshāpur. They will be gone for a few weeks, and so, you have the place to yourself—you might even sleep in Mariam’s bed tonight—it’s so much softer—well, if your guilty conscious allows it.

Anyway, you wanted some fresh air and that’s how you got here. Well, wherever here is. Getting back is a problem for later. You hear some rumbling in the distance, but the sun is still as hot as ever. Luckily, the courtyard has a little pond, so you plant yourself under a small palm tree next to the water. Nice and cool. Ready to read Lord Ioannis’s notes undisturbed. They are in Latin, which makes it a little harder, for you haven’t read Latin in ages. Like this passage about *Augustus Zenon*, that he was like superman, his kneecaps not attached to his knees, but moving freely.¹ That doesn’t really sound right, doesn’t it? And also that he was made *Augustus* [Emperor] by his six-year old son Leo?² How was that possible? Picture this: a little boy holding this big golden crown in his hands, shaking his head and saying

~“Daddy, this is too heavy. You take it! I wanna play outside with my ball.” And then the daddy goes

~“Okay. If you insist. And then I will make a law that no one can stop you from playing with your ball.”

~“Yay!”

But since Zenon was a barbarian, his mother-in-law, the widow Verina didn’t approve. So, she tried to put instead her brother Basiliskos on

¹Excerpta Valesiana Posterior, 40.

²Excerpta Valesiana Posterior, 39.

the throne. But then *Rex* Thiudareiks came to emperor Zenon's rescue—well, Thiudareiks was not *Rex* yet then, but *Augustus* Zenon gave him the rank of patrician and allowed him to move against Verina's nephew Audowakrs, who had usurped the throne of Italia—probably doing honor to his name, Audowakrs, which in Gothic means 'awake for getting rich'. At least, that's what you can paste together from what you also read in that Prokopios guy. Funny, though, that these books were often so vague and at times even contradictory. One would think, history is just recording what happened, right? But probably people forget, and then they make up something?

The author of these writings praises *Rex* Thiudareiks for his wisdom, in spite of being unlettered. There is this nice example how clever he was. See, there is this widow. And her son, as a baby, is taken by his kin to some other place where the boy is raised. Only when he is of age, he returns to his old home and finds his mother. And she is so happy to see her long lost son and she tells him to come live with her. And so mother and son are united again. These kind of stories always tear you up, as you imagine to be reunited with your own mother. But that's not possible anymore—may her soul rest in peace!

But the story goes on. The mother, she has a jealous suitor. And when he returns from his trip, he asks,

~"Woman, who is this young man who is living here?"

~"He is my son, my love."

~"I will not have this youngster live in our house! If you want to marry me, then denounce him, for I will not share you with him!" So, the mother, who has completely fallen smitten with her suitor, she abides—kind of not very motherly. The son thinks so too and he goes complain to *Rex* Thiudareiks. So the *Rex* summons the widow and asks

~"This youngster claims to be your son and heir of your estate." Prodded by her suitor, she denies that he is her son. But the son insists with the *Rex*, and so the *Rex* asks

~"How large is the sum of your possessions."

~"Six-thousand gold pieces." You never even have seen a single gold piece, so presumably, that is a lot of money. No wonder why the suitor wants it all for himself. And then *Rex* Thiudareiks says

~"This young man lived in your house for an entire month. And so, to avoid shame upon yourself and our people, you shall marry him!" See, that is so smart: the *Rex* knows that a mother would never marry her

son—well, Goths wouldn't—the Persians, that is another story. So, the mother has no choice but to confess.

~“He is my son, sire. And he is my heir.” The author does not say what happens to the greedy suitor, but you hope he is scorned, left utterly devastated. That's what he deserves for wanting to separate a mother from her child just for the sake of money! In the manuscript, it only says: and many more stories of the same kind are related of the *Rex*.³ But the author doesn't give them. Such a pity. One can learn a lot from the wisdom of kings. Like *Rex* Thiudareiks's wise sayings. This one is kind of funny:

~“The Roman when in misery imitates the Goth, and the Goth when in comfort imitates the Roman.”⁴ You don't exactly know what it means, for you are obviously either, ha, ha. You wonder what the *Rex* would say about you and the Persians. It probably would go something like this:

Three girls are sitting on a bar in Weh-Andiyok-Husrow: a Gothic girl, a Roman girl, and a Persian girl. And the Gothic girl says

~“I will marry a handsome Persian boy, so that I will be the envy of all Goths.” And the Roman girl says,

~“Pfff, I'll do you one better: I will marry a Persian prince, so that I will be the envy of all Romans.” And the Persian girl says,

~“You'd better envy me, for I will be the Persian *Bāmbishnān-Bāmbishn* [Queen of Queens], and you'll do as I say!” Ha, ha. The rumbling in the distance has become louder, and the sun has disappeared, making it all of a sudden much darker in the courtyard. You hope you did not anger one of the Persian gods with your little joke. You continue reading *Rex* Thiudareiks's words of wisdom. This one is a little more vexing as the Latin is quite oblique. It says

~“Aurum et daemonem qui habet, non eum potest abscondere.”⁵ It's about gold and demons, and one cannot hide one from the other? Or, one cannot hide from them? Or something altogether different? While still pondering this over, you are startled by a loud thunderbolt. That was much closer by! And to make their case, the weather gods start pouring rain. First a few drops, and then a few more. . . . The rain is going to ruin your parchments. You need to find shelter! You look around, but it is now quite dark and in your panic, you only can see a small subterranean door,

³Excerpta Valesiana Posterior, 62.

⁴Excerpta Valesiana Posterior, 61.

⁵Excerpta Valesiana Posterior, 61.

wherever it leads to—hopefully not to the dungeons—that is your only hope to stay dry. So, you jump up and run as fast as you can down the couple of steps into the little cellar. You turn around to look outside, just in time as a downpour has started, and water is splashing everywhere. So, you go further inside the cellar, until you hear some noise behind you.

—“*Drōd* [Hello], you came!” Someone was expecting you? Perhaps he had been watching you secretly while you were reading? You quickly turn around and let out a little gasp. In the back, on a small table, lit by a single torch, is a middle-aged Persian sitting, and when he sees you, he gets up. When the flickering torch reveals his features, you are actually no longer sure whether he is Persian. He is quite scrawny yet stocky, his hair is different, straw-like, his nose is way too flat, and his eyes too far apart, and... You realize that you are staring at him, so you ask, perhaps a little too pertly:

—“*Drōd*, and who might you be?”

—“The master of the *dewān* [demons]!” IESOUS! MARIAM! IOSEF! Did he just say that he was the master of the demons? Where did you end up? So, you stutter

—“The ... the *dew* [demon] ..., the *dewān*?”

—“Yes. Awaiting you to give the gold due to you!” Is this the meaning of the *Rex*’s aphorism: demons hiding gold? For you? You want to turn around and run away, but another loud thunderbolt, accompanied by a gust of wind, blows out the flame in the torch. The only light now comes from lightning flashes outside. It is so eerie that you almost want to cry. And then another gust slams the door shut. You are trapped and the master of the demons is coming for you!